

The Impact of Remote and Digital Communication on Workplace Conflict

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The shift toward remote and digital communication has reshaped how workplaces function. Tools like Slack, Zoom, Microsoft Teams, and email have become the primary way employees interact, replacing many face-to-face conversations. While these tools increase flexibility and efficiency, they also reshape how conflict develops and escalates. In many cases, conflict is no longer driven by major disagreements but by misinterpretation, lack of context, and emotional overload in digital environments. As communication becomes more mediated, small misunderstandings can quickly escalate into larger organizational tensions. Research consistently shows that digital communication does not inherently create conflict, but it amplifies existing communication weaknesses and reduces the social cues people rely on to interpret meaning. This paper argues that workplace conflict in digital environments is primarily driven by reduced social cues, increased cognitive and emotional strain, weakened interpersonal trust, and blurred work boundaries, all of which interact to intensify misunderstanding and reactive behavior.

One of the most consistent findings across communication research is that digital environments remove nonverbal cues that normally stabilize meaning. In face-to-face interaction, tone, facial expression, and body language provide immediate context that helps clarify intent. Without these signals, messages become more ambiguous and open to interpretation. Aguillon and Cronin-Gilmore (2024), researchers in organizational communication, explain that when nonverbal cues are missing, “the human brain naturally tries to fill in the blanks,” which often leads individuals to assume unintended negativity (p. 181). This cognitive gap is important because it shifts communication from shared meaning to individual interpretation, increasing the likelihood of miscommunication.

This issue is reinforced by what Yang et al. (2021), describe as a “silo effect” in remote work environments. Their large-scale research demonstrates that when employees are physically and socially separated, they lose the informal interactions that normally build trust. Without that baseline trust, individuals are less likely to interpret ambiguous messages charitably. Instead, neutral communication is more likely to be perceived as hostile or dismissive. This combination of missing cues and weakened trust creates a condition where misunderstanding becomes structurally more likely, not just individually possible.

Media Richness Theory (Daft & Lengel, 1986) helps explain why these misunderstandings escalate. The theory argues that communication channels differ in their ability to convey meaning, with face-to-face communication being the richest and text-based communication being the leanest. Lean communication is less effective for complex or emotional exchanges because it lacks immediate feedback and nonverbal reinforcement. Venkatesh, Aljafari, and Hoehle (2024) support this idea by showing that response behavior in digital communication directly affects “collaborative performance,” especially when messages are ambiguous. When collaboration relies heavily on text-based tools, even minor misunderstandings can undermine overall team effectiveness and increase friction among employees.

However, misinterpretation is only part of the issue. Digital communication also increases cognitive and emotional strain, which directly impacts how people respond to conflict. Shin et al. (2025), who study communication technology and workplace well-being, found that frequent switching between communication platforms contributes to cognitive overload. This constant task switching reduces emotional regulation, making individuals more reactive in communication. In practice, this means employees are not only interpreting messages differently

but also responding under higher levels of mental fatigue, which increases the likelihood of conflict escalation.

This emotional strain is closely connected to psychological distress in remote environments. Eng, Sharp, and Islam (2025), whose research appears in the -found that remote work is associated with increased “psychological distress,” particularly due to isolation and blurred work boundaries. Their findings suggest that stress does not remain separate from communication but directly influences it. When employees are already experiencing burnout or distress, even neutral messages can feel more personal or threatening, increasing emotional reactivity and reducing communication patience.

Work-family conflict further intensifies this effect. Rabin et al. (2024), explain that remote work increases “work-family conflict” because employees struggle to separate personal and professional roles. This constant overlap eliminates psychological recovery time, meaning stress accumulates across the day rather than resetting after work hours. As stress builds, tolerance for ambiguity decreases, making misunderstandings more likely and conflicts more intense. Taken together with Shin et al. (2025) and Eng et al. (2025), the research shows a consistent pattern: digital communication does not just change how people talk, it changes their emotional capacity to handle communication itself.

At the same time, digital communication is not entirely negative. Cai and Ali (2024), provide a more balanced perspective by showing that enterprise social media can also “foster innovative behaviors” and improve collaboration when used effectively. Their findings are important because they demonstrate that digital platforms are not inherently conflict-driven; instead, outcomes depend on communication structure and usage. This aligns with the idea that

conflict arises not from technology itself but from how it shapes interpretation, timing, and relational context.

The dual nature of digital communication becomes clearer when considering how communication can either buffer or intensify conflict. Singh et al. (2024), researchers in organizational communication, argue that communication acts as a “buffer” in workplace conflict, meaning it can reduce tension when used effectively but amplify it when poorly managed. This idea connects directly to earlier findings because it shows that trust, clarity, and emotional regulation all depend on communication quality rather than communication presence. When communication is unclear or avoided, tension does not disappear; it accumulates and resurfaces in more disruptive forms.

When all of these factors interact, digital communication environments begin to produce predictable patterns of conflict escalation. Reduced social cues increase misinterpretation, weakened trust reduces charitable interpretation, cognitive overload reduces emotional regulation, and psychological distress increases sensitivity to perceived conflict. These effects do not operate independently; instead, they reinforce one another. A single ambiguous message can therefore trigger a chain reaction: misinterpretation, emotional response, escalation, and relational strain.

Because of this, managing conflict in digital environments requires more than simple etiquette rules. It requires intentional communication practices that address both interpretation and emotional state. One key strategy is pausing before responding, which allows individuals to separate emotional reaction from interpretation. Another is increasing clarity in messages to reduce ambiguity, especially in high-stakes communication. Building relational trust through

consistent positive interactions is also critical, since trust reduces the likelihood of negative interpretation in the first place.

Ultimately, workplace conflict in digital environments is not simply a communication problem but a structural condition shaped by how technology changes human interaction. The research from Aguilon and Cronin-Gilmore (2024), Cai and Ali (2024), Eng et al. (2025), Rabin et al. (2024), Shin et al. (2025), Singh et al. (2024), Venkatesh, Aljafari, and Hoehle (2024), and Yang et al. (2021) collectively demonstrates that digital communication affects cognition, emotion, and social trust simultaneously. These combined effects explain why conflict is more frequent and more easily escalated in remote environments.

In conclusion, remote and digital communication does not inherently create workplace conflict, but it significantly increases the likelihood of conflict. The absence of nonverbal cues increased cognitive load, psychological distress, and weakened interpersonal relationships all of which contribute to a communication environment where misunderstanding is more likely and emotional reactions are amplified. However, the same research also shows that these outcomes are not inevitable. With intentional communication practices and stronger relational awareness, organizations can reduce unnecessary conflict and improve collaboration even in fully digital environments.

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